

The General Will and the Paradox of Being "Forced to Be Free": Rousseau's Social Contract

An original lesson plan inspired by **Jean-Jacques Rousseau's** *The Social Contract & Discourses* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Jean-Jacques Rousseau. Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/46333>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Political Philosophy

“Rousseau claims that by submitting to the 'general will' of the community, and even being 'forced to be free,' individuals become more free, not less. Is this a profound insight into political freedom, or a dangerous justification for coercion in the name of the people?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Rousseau's diagnosis of how humans move from natural freedom to the corruptions of civil society and private property.
- Define the 'general will' as Rousseau uses it, and distinguish it from the mere sum of individual private wills (the 'will of all').
- Evaluate Rousseau's claim that submitting to the general will, even when it overrules one's private judgment, makes a person more free.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: the opening of Book I of *The Social Contract*, including the passage on being 'forced to be free,' plus a short passage from the *Discourse on Inequality* on the origins of property
- Case-study scenario: a town-hall vote on managing a shared community resource
- Two-column worksheet: 'general will' vs. 'will of all'

Lesson Procedure

Hook: "Man Is Born Free, But Everywhere He Is in Chains"

8 min

Read Rousseau's famous opening line aloud and ask students what they think it means. Ask whether the 'chains' metaphor is about literal oppression, lost natural freedom, or something else, and collect a range of predictions before moving on.

Direct Instruction: From Natural Freedom to Civil Society

18 min

Briefly present Rousseau's account, from the Discourse on Inequality, of how the introduction of private property corrupted an originally free and equal state of nature into one of dependency and inequality. Pivot to The Social Contract's proposed solution: a form of association in which each person, uniting with all, obeys only themselves and remains as free as before, by submitting to the general will rather than to any particular person's will.

Small-Group Simulation: The Shared Resource Vote

16 min

Run the town-hall case: students vote on rules for managing a shared community resource. Afterward, in groups, they distinguish which parts of the outcome reflected the 'general will,' what is genuinely good for the community as a whole, versus the 'will of all,' the mere sum of everyone's private preferences, and discuss whether these differed.

Whole-Class Discussion: Forced to Be Free?

12 min

Unpack Rousseau's claim that anyone who refuses to obey the general will may be 'forced to be free' by the whole body. Debate whether this is a coherent idea of freedom or whether it risks licensing coercion of dissenters in the name of what's supposedly good for them.

Closure

6 min

Return to the opening line and ask students to reinterpret it in light of what they've learned about the general will and the origins of inequality.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Rousseau distinguishes the 'general will,' aimed at the common good, from the 'will of all,' the mere sum of private wills. Is this a meaningful distinction, or is the 'general will' just whatever Rousseau wants to call correct, dressed up as something the community collectively wills?
- 2 What did you think Rousseau's opening line meant before the lesson, and how did your reading change after learning about his account of the origins of inequality?
- 3 Is it coherent to say that someone can be 'forced to be free'? Can you think of a modern example, a law or a mandate, that a defender might justify this way, and would Rousseau's framework support or complicate that justification?
- 4 Rousseau argues that submitting to the general will makes you free because you're only obeying a law you, as part of the sovereign people, authored. Does this work if you were outvoted and personally disagree with the law?
- 5 Rousseau's ideas about popular sovereignty influenced the French Revolution, sometimes invoked to justify quite different, even authoritarian, outcomes. What does this suggest about the risks of grounding political legitimacy in something as abstract as a 'general will'?

Assessment

Students write a short response defending or challenging Rousseau's claim that submitting to the general will makes an individual more free, using the shared-resource simulation from class as their central example, and explicitly addressing the 'forced to be free' paradox.

Extension Activity

Have students find a real historical or contemporary example where a government or movement invoked 'the will of the people' to justify an action some citizens opposed, and write a short analysis of whether that invocation reflects Rousseau's 'general will' or is closer to what he calls the mere 'will of all.'

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